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STATEMENT OF TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

“By learning you will teach; by teaching you will learn” Latin proverb
“Tell me and I’ll forget. Show me, and I may not remember. Involve me, and I’ll understand” Native American saying

I strive to engage and challenge my students. It is my belief that every student should absorb the passion that I feel for the topics that I teach in speech pathology by becoming collaborators in the exploration of theory, research, and practice. My national and international clinical and academic journey provided me experiences and opportunities to observe instructors, clinicians, and students from many disciplines and of many skill levels that shaped my teaching philosophy.

The most important goal is to create a learning environment that is conducive of active learning and evidence-based. This is true whether teaching formally or informally, and whether my audience consists of undergraduate students, graduate clinicians, or patients. My style of teaching is practical, experiential, and occasionally humorous, which I believe leads to a collaborative learning process that benefits everyone involved.

Three very important elements in my educational philosophy; respect for the learner, appreciating different learning styles and continuous refinement of the teaching process. In my opinion, these elements are linked. In fact, how I use them to define my educational approach is outlined below.

Respect for the learner

In the teacher-learner dyad, each element influences the success of the educational encounter. Engaging the learner is critical. One must start by gauging the needs of the learner, tailoring the approach to the learner, and ensuring a safe learning environment. Further, respecting the learner entails encouragement of experimentation and taking chances. Consistent with this attitude of respect is my willingness to accept error and correct it quickly when it occurs. In fact, honesty about expectations, successes and mistakes is the foundation for the respect that will insure optimal learning.

Appreciating different learning styles

As a teacher of undergraduate and graduate students, it is important to recognize and accept the diversity that is in our classrooms today. Although, there are obvious forms of diversity in classrooms like language and ethnic background differences, my focus is not on overcoming ethnic discrimination or working towards inclusion and understanding. On the contrary, I focus towards recognizing and appreciating the diversity of students as individual learners. By providing different learning opportunities for different learning styles, I can maximize learning potentials for my students as well as help my students to choose the learning techniques that work best for them.

Continuous refinement of the teaching process

Each teaching session is an experiment, blending unique learning needs and teaching methods. Assessment and evaluation are integral part of the learning process that ensure quality and help prevent the same errors from occurring over time. I believe that accepting feedback and respecting that people learn differently helps me in my continuous refinement of courses. Without looking back at what we have done we are not informed about what we might do.

These three basic approaches to teaching are embodied in the active and reflective style of teaching I feel most comfortable with. I engage my students early-on in the course syllabus planning; probe what they know, what they think and what is the best course of action. I continue to build on what they know and help them discover their own ability to become good clinicians. This approach empowers students to take responsibility in the learning process, regardless of their level of training.